

THE CURSE OF DIDIGIRI

By espousing the cause of the displaced farmers, Mamata Banerjee was not taking on India's most respected business house but the Left Front Government. The Tatas have the option to shift out but the Marxists could face a real threat of being turfed out.

Photographs by SUBIR HALDAR



■ By Elora Sen

Didigiri. If there is one word that best sums up the brand of politics that Mamata Banerjee practices, it is this. Thanks, in part, to her political baptism in the Chhatra Parishad, the Congress student wing in West Bengal, Banerjee has always had a love affair with street-level politics—always high on drama, often low on content. The Singur saga showed that the affair endures. Whether the Nano—Ratan Tata's dream car—rolls out from there remains to be seen. But what the last two weeks have shown is that while the Left may be in power, it is Didi who rules.

Banerjee's power lies in her raw

magnetism that simply pulls the masses towards her. When she deems fit, she can go to any extent to be heard. The rest of India may have seen bandhs and hartals protesting inflation and the nuclear deal this past fortnight, but in West Bengal, Banerjee threw life out of gear because she was determined to throw out India's most respected business house. It mattered little to her that other states and even Sri Lanka were queueing up to welcome the Tatas, lock, stock and crankshaft. She needs the limelight like the rest of us need oxygen. So whether you are cursing her for bringing the state to a halt or you are falling at her feet acknowledging her as a saviour, there is no escaping Banerjee.

RABBLE-ROUSER: Banerjee at a rally outside the Tata factory

It has been that way ever since she joined the big league in the 1984 Lok Sabha elections and defeated then Marxist strongman Somnath Chatterjee in Jadavpur. Even as a first-term parliamentarian, she never baulked at embarrassing the government, unmindful of the fact that she belonged to the ruling party. The rebel streak continued even when she became a minister at the Centre, once squatting in the well of the House to protest the hike in petroleum prices. Banerjee and bandhs have almost become synonymous in Kolkata and in her defence, she says it is her demo-